

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a local newspaper:

China schools seek to nip young love in the bud

In recent weeks a number of mainland Chinese secondary schools have introduced new rules designed to discourage teenage dating and romance. Many people are unhappy about the new rules.

In one secondary school in Hangzhou, pupils of the opposite sex have been given a very important new instruction. They must maintain a minimum distance of half a metre from each other at all times. In addition, boys and girls are not allowed to go around school premises in pairs.

Another school, in the eastern city of Wenzhou, Zhejiang province, has banned what it calls “close interaction” between students of the opposite sex as well as students of the same sex. They do not define what “close interaction” really means.

The school authorities in Wenzhou have threatened “severe punishment” against offenders.

Secondary schools in China admit students aged just 11 – they are just at the point when they become interested in the opposite sex.

And with reports that teenage romance has become more popular at schools, school authorities – as well as parents – are worried that children’s academic performance is being affected.

Some schools have moved to stop the young love with the implementation of tight measures – and they will certainly find support from some.

Many Chinese regard teenage romance as something undesirable – a feeling that “early love” is immature love – and this helps explain why schools are increasingly teaching young people about the “undesirable effects” of dating.

A parent has complained to your school principal about his child dating another student. Your class has been asked to discuss whether there should be guidelines about dating. You may want to talk about:

- whether you agree with the no dating rule adopted in China
- the advantages and disadvantages of secondary school students dating
- guidelines or advice schools should give students about dating
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. How do parents feel about students dating?
2. Is dating common among secondary school students?
3. Do students focus too much on their social life and not enough on their studies?
4. Have attitudes to dating changed since your parents were young?
5. Is dating good for developing social skills?
6. Should students tell their parents if they are dating?
7. How would you feel if your school stopped students from dating?
8. Do attitudes to dating in Hong Kong differ from those in China?